



While Tisket braced herself against the wall, Maarika pried off the faceplate of the control panel and quickly started stripping wires, clipping and taping them together in various combinations before plugging the fat bundle into her laptop. Out in the hallway, Ranveig's axe ricocheted off what sounded a suit of armor with a loud clang. Tisket heard the thump of many booted feet as Sevastyan's vassals flooded the hall to defend the tower from its intruders.

"I'm sure you're going as fast as you can," a recovered Tisket said to Maarika, who furiously typed white code onto a black screen. "No reason whatsoever to go faster, when you're obviously doing everything you can."

"This *is* faster. I keep telling you it doesn't look like it does on TV," Maarika said.

"I'm sure doing something with more colors won't help," Tisket said.

Maarika exhaled through her nose in a frustrated huff. "Aesthetics won't make it faster, Tisk."

"Yeah, right."

Out in the hall, Ranveig shouted, "By the honor of my lady Maarika, you shall not breach this threshold, you pusillanimous Varich lackeys!"

"Yay," Tisket said, deadpan. "She's breaking out the thesaurus. The fight must be going so well."

"Did Ranveig just say 'pusillanimous'?" Gibraltar asked over the comms.

"Yes, Gib," Maarika sighed, typing faster.

"It's never a good sign when she starts getting all erudite," Gibraltar says.

"We're at 10 minutes and counting, Maarika," Dolaidh said.

"I know, I know," Maarika said. "I'm going as fast as I — yes! I'm in!"

The vault door let out a hiss and then slid into the wall as billows of steam rolled from the newly-opened space. Maarika and Tisket stood in front of the doorway, peering through the steam. They could see the tops of file cabinets.

A soft voice said, "Security breach. Please identify."

"Is that the security system?" Gibraltar asked. "I thought you just hacked that."

"I did. This is a... secondary security system, I assume," Maarika said.